

Puppy Vaccination Schedule

A quick-reference handout. Your veterinarian sets the exact timeline based on your puppy's age, health, and lifestyle. The single most important dose is the final one, given at or after 16 weeks, because by then maternal antibody has usually faded enough for the vaccine to take.

Core vaccines are recommended for essentially every dog. The main combination shot is labeled DHPP or DAPP and covers distemper, hepatitis (canine adenovirus), parainfluenza, and parvovirus. Rabies is also a core vaccine and is required by law. Under the 2022 AAHA guidelines, leptospirosis is now classified as a core vaccine recommended for all dogs.

6 to 8 weeks of age: puppies get their first round of core vaccines.

Every 2 to 4 weeks after that: boosters continue until the puppy is at least 16 weeks old, usually three or four rounds in total. The final dose at or after 16 weeks matters most.

12 to 16 weeks: the rabies vaccine is given, with the exact timing set by state and local law. A booster is due one year later, then repeated every one to three years depending on the product and local law.

Full protection comes about one to two weeks after the final core round, around 16 to 18 weeks of age. Until then, socialize carefully and avoid high-risk public places like dog parks, pet stores, and busy sidewalks.

Non-core vaccines are recommended for some dogs based on lifestyle and risk, including Bordetella, canine influenza, and Lyme disease. Many boarding and daycare facilities require the Bordetella vaccine.

Keep a written or digital record of every vaccine, including the date and which product was given. You will need proof of rabies vaccination for licensing, travel, boarding, daycare, and grooming.